



USING AI TO FACILITATE FEEDBACK ON THE LEARNING EXPERIENCES OF DOCTORAL STUDENTS

📅 12 Dec 2025

2025-12-12

- Gabriele Cabral, Causal Map Ltd
- James Copestake, University of Bath
- Steve Powell, Causal Map Ltd

Summary

The Causal Map team has conducted a trial of an innovative approach to securing feedback from students using online open-ended interviews conducted by the app [QualiaInterviews](#), which uses generative AI (gen-AI), followed by a second use of gen-AI within the app **Causal Map** to semi-automate causal coding of the narrative transcripts thereby generated. The trial was conducted with students registered on the doctorate in policy research and practice (DPRP) at the **University of Bath**.

The pilot

We report on the trial of an innovative approach to securing feedback from students using online open-ended interviews conducted by the app Qualia, which uses generative AI (gen-AI), followed by a second use of gen-AI within the app Causal Map to semi-automate causal coding of the narrative transcripts thereby generated. The trial was conducted with students registered on the doctorate in policy research and practice (DPRP) at the University of Bath, a part-time programme for mid-career policy professionals. This generated credible evidence of diverse positive and negative drivers of learning from eleven students. The trial suggests that incorporation of gen-AI into causal mapping of narrative data about students' study experiences enhances the potential to use the method cost-effectively on a larger scale, whether alongside or instead of more traditional approaches to eliciting student feedback on teaching and learning.

Keywords: *AI; Causal mapping; Doctoral studies; Generative AI; Qualitative data analysis, Student evaluation*

